

7.2 Show me the Path

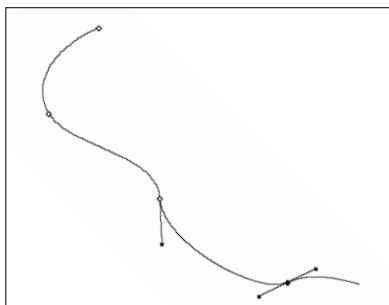
Many Photoshop users shy away from paths, mainly because the way they are drawn greatly differs from our “traditional” idea of drawing things. Once you get used to it, though, paths are really easy, and you can use them for a variety of different purposes.

What you can do with paths:

- Fill them with colour to create vector graphics
- Convert them to selections when the standard selection tools fail to accurately select the area you want.
- Use them as vector masks to hide areas of a layer (more on vector masks in the next chapter)

What’s The Point?

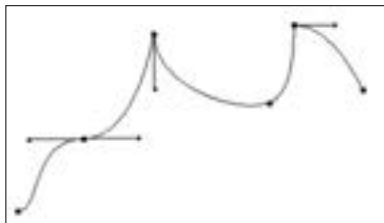
Paths are primarily segments of lines and curves which terminate at points called *Anchor Point*. Each anchor point then has two *Direction Lines*—one which shows the direction of the segment entering the point, and one for the segment leaving it.



A typical path with Anchor Points and Direction Lines

There are two types of anchor points:

- *Smooth Points*, which connect smooth curves. Direction lines on smooth points always move together to keep this smoothness intact.
- *Corner Points*, which, as the name suggests, con-



Smooth Points and Corner Points